

ELECTRICAL OUTLET

Please don't take this to mean a "real" outlet. You can use a method similar to the return-air-vent technique to create your own wall cubby that most smart burglars won't attempt to touch. You can also skip the work of the DIY method, and buy one pre-made.

These are places you *shouldn't* hide cash:

UNDER THE MATTRESS

This is one of the first places thieves are going to check, and it is hardly conducive to a good night's sleep.

TOILET TANK

Several websites still list this as a good place to hide money. (Too bad every mob movie I've seen with home invasion as a pervasive theme directs the goons toward this niche first.) The only thing going into my toilet tank is a freshening tab (or possibly a brick to save on water usage).

PURSE

Yep, it's been said that a lady with a large purse collection should pick some random handbag and stick it in there. Chances are good, how-

ever, that this totally-out-in-the-open hiding place is a little too available for many thieves. Don't you want them to have to at least work for it? (And what if the thief has a penchant for Prada, Kate Spade, or Jaclyn Smith?)

A few other pointers for those who want to conceal cash in their home include:

Be aware that many homemade safes (including those I mentioned) won't make your valuables immune from fire damage. If you are concerned about the possibility of your nest egg going up in flames, consider a fireproof case or bag.

Leave a clue to where you keep it. If you should happen to die or disappear for a really, really long time, would your loved ones know where you keep your cash? Unless you want your valuables to be of no use to anyone else in your passing, let a few close relatives or a trusted friend know your plans. You may also want to have it clearly explained in your "top-secret" will.

Make sure you have the value of your cash added to your home owner's or rental insurance, if at all possible. Some companies will have specific regulations as to what they can and can't cover. If you have large amounts of cash on the premises, however, see how you can best minimize loss in a bad situation using your insurance plan. — **Linsey Knerl**